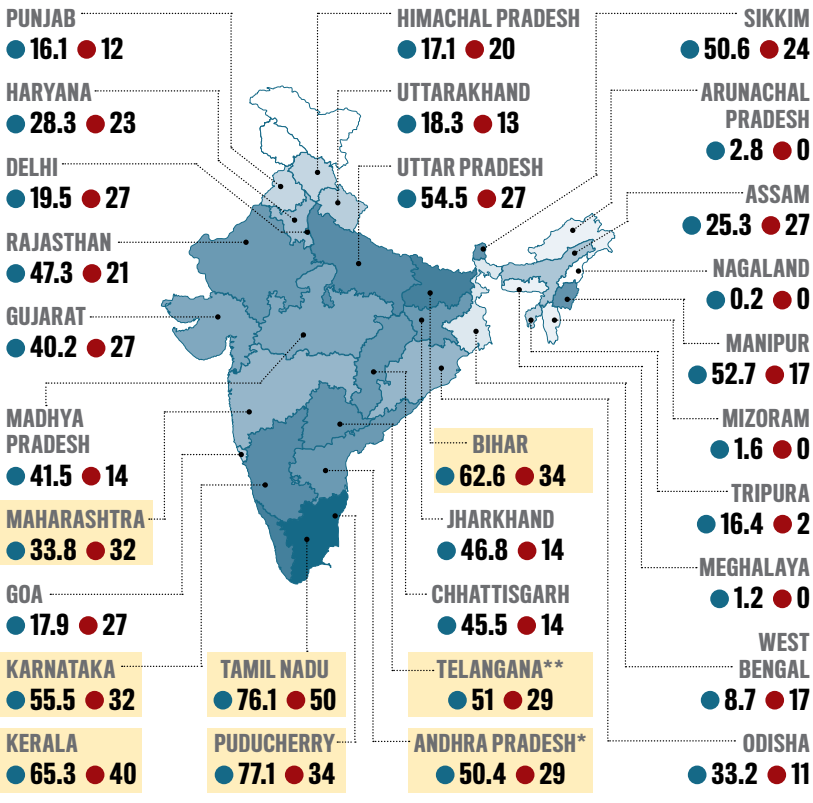
THE RESERVATION ROSTER

THE QUANTUM OF RESERVATIONS STATES AND SOME UTs KEEP ASIDE FOR THEIR ESTIMATED OBC POPULATIONS



(OBC quota % also includes that for MBC and other such sub-sects recognised by states)

*Population sources: National Sample Survey 2011-12, *of undivided Andhra Pradesh, **from Telangana government website; Quota source: state government data*

The highlighted states have more than the mandated 27% OBC quota. Some states which have a less-than-the-national-average population of SC/STs have adjusted that quota with an increased OBC reservation. While Tamil Nadu has received 9th Schedule inclusion to also exceed the SC's 50% reservation cap, Bihar has sought similar relief

ism—and its electoral correlate of a solid Hindu vote bank. As corroborative proof, there also existed earlier speeches by the prime minister where he had said that, for him, there were only four castes: the youth, women, the poor and farmers.

Opposition megaphones piled on the dire messaging, not without a touch of hyperbole of their own. Ambedkar's Constitution was under threat, they said, along with the array of rights and protections it offered. This could be the "last election", warned Congress president Mallikarjun Kharge, among others, and it was a battle to "save democracy" itself. Even stripped of its extreme coating, the seed idea spread in the wind: that the BJP intended to end reservations. The Opposition's campaign began gaining traction among the target cohorts: the Scheduled Castes, who constitute 16.6 per cent of India's population according to the 2011 census; the Scheduled Tribes, who make up 8.6 per cent; and the mass of OBCs, who make up an unknown but significant majority.

DALIT DISQUIET

The subject opened up historical wounds and began to create vote-bloc dissonance on all sides. The ones really stung to the quick were the Dalits, very many of whom had over the decades liberated themselves from degrading social apartheids and economic privations only because reservations had handed them the keys to the prison lock. "For Dalits, reservation is what land is for the farmer," says political scientist-activist Yogendra Yadav. "They will not permit or tolerate even the slightest possibility of that being touched." Also, as an electoral factor, that perceived threat too is nearly exclusive to Dalits, says Suhas Palshikar, co-director, Lokniti-CSDS, because of the "emotional connect with Babasaheb and the Constitution".

In practical terms, Dalit reservations are virtually a closed, inviolate circle—and the 'threat' to it more a spectral one. No party may hazard to venture anywhere close to it, but that the thought could even arise was enough of a spur. The grittier battle—more open-ended—is about the cluster of hues at the end of the rainbow occupied by the OBCs. Unlike the Dalits, whose population is known from the census, the OBCs have not been enumerated since 1931, except now in Bihar: so the caste census pertains properly to them. The very real possibility of a formal headcount far exceeding the 1931 figure of 52 per cent accepted by Mandal, and that catalysing a demand for OBC quotas to not be confined within the existing 27 per cent, could both spook elite-caste voters all over again, like it did in the 1990s, as also disrupt the BJP's quest for a unified Hindu vote.

For, this was like a subterranean polarisation flowing under Hindutva. Caste with a capital 'C'—a meta factor. It had a visibly catalytic effect on the mint-fresh INDIA bloc—by some reckonings, with key battleground states in heated contest, there was even talk of their gaining critical mass. The lukewarm voting in the first two phases that saw an average four percentage point drop in turnout came as another warning sign for the ruling party. The BJP sensed